

ACADEMIC SKILLS FOR STANFORD STUDENTS

NOTE-TAKING GUIDE

WHY TAKE NOTES?

Concentration on lecture/reading

- Note taking keeps you focused, whether you're in class or reading your textbook.
- Writing notes means that you're kinesthetically processing information.

Resource for homework and test prep

- Your notes will help you study for tests and tackle assignments.
- Notes often contain information that can't be found anywhere else—including the internet and your textbook—and provide clues as to what the instructor finds most important.

Enhanced learning

- Taking proper notes means you are filtering through information and thoroughly encoding it.
- By writing content in your own words and choosing the most important things to write down, you're building connections between what you already know and what you're learning.

DON'T: Use complete sentences or worry about spelling and grammar.

DO: Streamline information by using abbreviations and shortcuts.

DON'T: Try to write down everything the lecturer or textbook is saying.

DO: Take notes selectively. Capture main ideas and subpoints.

DON'T: Take unorganized, free-form notes.

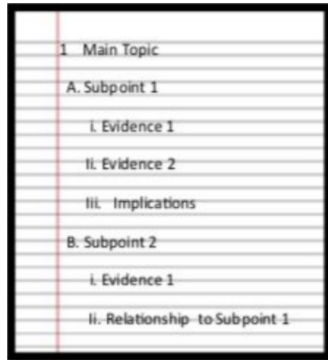
DO: Use some kind of structure to organize your notes. See the following page of this handout for formats you can experiment with!

DON'T: Copy definitions and concepts verbatim.

DO: Use your own words. It might seem slower at first, but it gets easier with practice!

NOTE-TAKING METHODS

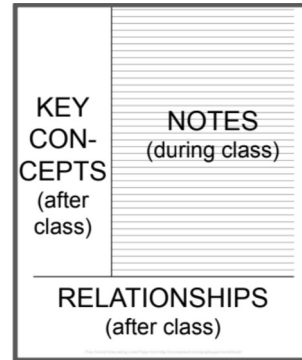
Have lots of conceptual information?



...try OUTLINING!

Tools to try: OneNote, Google Docs, Evernote

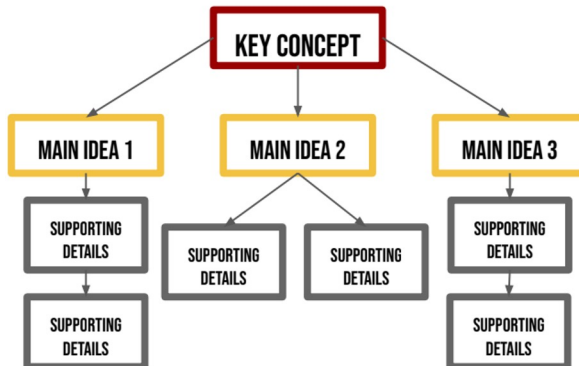
Need a tried-and-true study tool?



...try CORNELL NOTES!

Tools to try: Incompetech Cornell Lined Paper

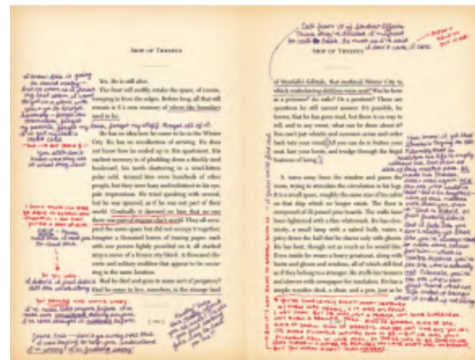
Want to visualize processes, ordered information, or models?



...try CONCEPT MAPPING!

Tools to try: Lucidchart, Popplet, SimpleMind

Have lots of reading or downloaded lecture slides?



...try ANNOTATING!

Tools to try: Notability, PDF, Expert, Xodo

Stanford CTL does not endorse any particular app, tool, or company. Students have compiled and shared the above list of note-taking resources.

NOTE-TAKING TIPS FOR ONLINE LECTURES

- **Schedule a consistent time** to watch pre-recorded lectures, and make sure to review previous lectures' notes in advance.
- **Take breaks judiciously** between long or dense lectures to stay alert.
- **Listen for signals** that lecture material is worth jotting down:
 - **Numbers** in explanations (“Three main branches...”)
 - **Changes** in volume or tone of voice, or using more gestures
 - **Transitional language** (“therefore,” “consequently...”)
 - **Repeated information**, or topics that came up in readings
 - **Warnings** about common mistakes or misunderstandings